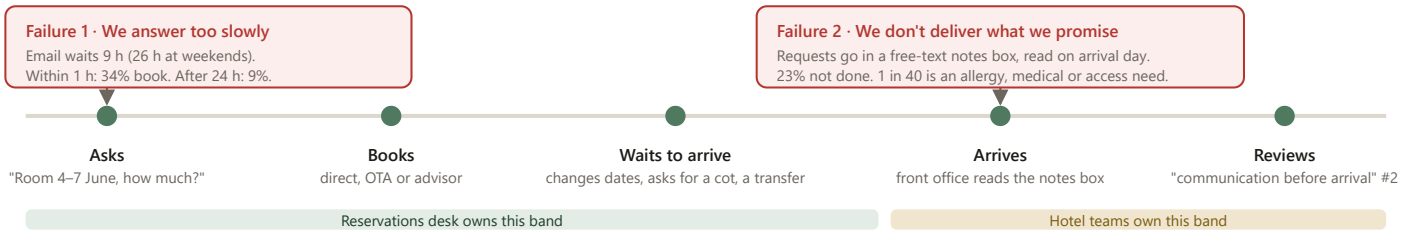
What Aurel should build with AI

Strategy memo · To: COO · From: AI Product Manager · 23 October 2026

> **Terms.** The **reservations desk** is the 22-person team that answers every guest contact before arrival (the brief calls it the CRO). The **PMS** is the hotel's booking system. A **trace** is a to-do in the PMS sent to a hotel department with a due date. **AI agent** is the software; **agent** on its own is a person on the desk.

1 Our read of the problem and the data

Two failures, both measurable, both in the band between a guest's first message and their arrival.

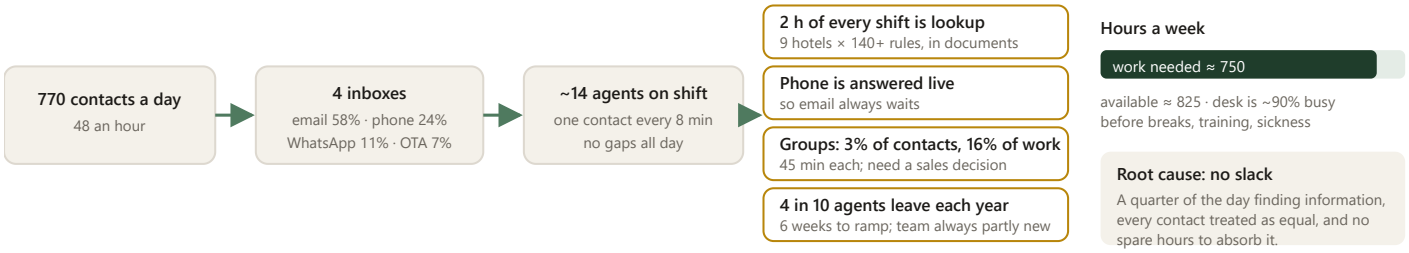


9 h / 26 h
median email reply, weekday / weekend

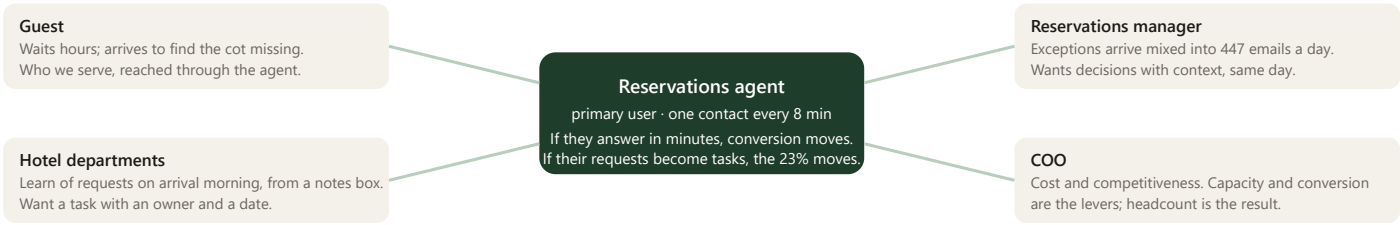
34% vs 9%
book if answered within 1 h vs after 24 h

224 / week
promises not kept (23% of 970 requests)

EUR 1.2M
a year, for each 1 point of enquiry conversion



2 Who we are solving for, and why

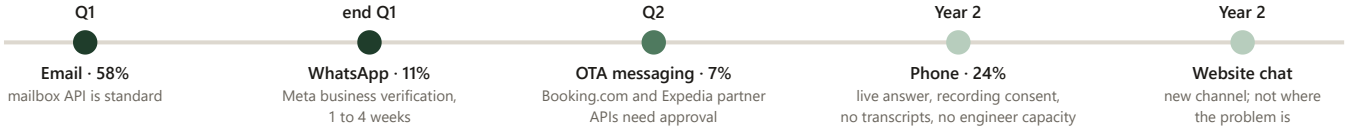


3 Vision: two to three years

An answer within the hour, on any channel, at any time. Every promise made before arrival is kept.

	Year 1 · these two quarters	Year 2	Year 3
Channels	Email Q1 · WhatsApp end Q1 OTA messaging Q2 (partner approval)	+ website chat + phone: AI agent helps the person on the call	+ phone handled by the AI agent for simple questions
Autonomy	Policy questions sent alone from the first live week Everything else drafted; a person approves	+ price quotes and within-rules changes sent alone 24/7 for those types	+ simple direct bookings at published prices via payment link; proactive pre-arrival outreach
Hotels	Every request is a trace with owner and due date	Hotels close traces; guest told automatically	"Promises kept" managed as a number across all 9 hotels
Team	Headcount reviewed end Q1, decided on Q2 data AI agent takes the lookup work	Team size decided on measured hours; roles shift to judgement and relationships	A guest-success team, not a queue

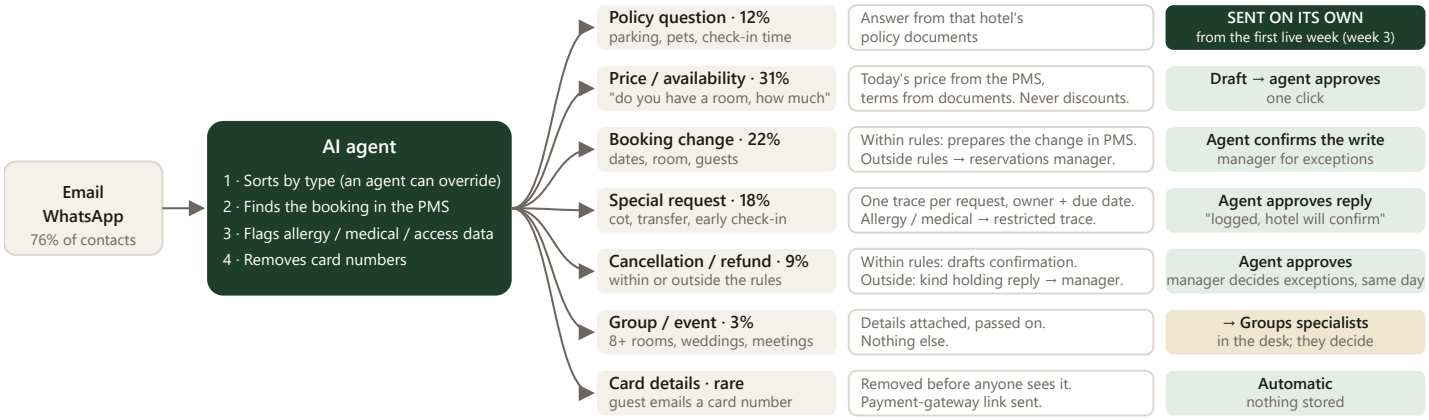
Why not every channel in three months. Writing the code is fast now. The gates are not code.



On every channel, sending alone is earned by being right on hundreds of checked messages. That takes real traffic and weeks, not code.

4 The one bet for these two quarters: the Aurel Reservations AI Agent

Sort every message by type, then send each type to the cheapest safe handler. Documents for policy questions. The PMS for prices. People for judgement calls. Traces for the hotels.



Rules it always follows: live PMS prices only · never confirms what the hotel has not · never discounts (rate parity) · never decides a refund outside the rules · sensitive data only in a restricted trace · each type earns the right to send alone when agents stop correcting it. Alongside, three work changes that need no software: enquiries answered first; phone and email shifts split by hour; traces compulsory with a weekly "promises kept" number per hotel.

Expected impact · today → end of Q2

Dark bar: realistic case. Light green: cautious case, where the AI agent delivers half of its share. Grey: today.

Hours of work a week

750 today
~615 cautious (18% less)
~480 realistic (36% less)

Where the ~270 saved hours come from (realistic case)
Quotes drafted with the live price 106 h · Changes prepared 60 h
Traces created 37 h · Policy-only answered alone 17 h
Call notes assisted 30 h · Cancellations drafted 18 h
Groups (122 h) need a sales decision; no saving counted.

Email reply, weekday median

9 h today
under 45 min cautious
under 30 min realistic

Requests not delivered

23% today
under 5% cautious
under 3% realistic

Money a year

EUR 5.7M to 11M

+5 to +10 points conversion on ~1,270 text enquiries a week × EUR 1,350, plus 18% OTA commission saved on them.

Fewer broken promises: real, not priced.

Headcount: no reduction planned; decided on measured hours.

Revenue is the prize, not headcount.

5 What we will not build

✕ A bot that books and takes payment alone
The PMS cannot take a card in a message. We need Q1 approval data before anything books unsupervised.

✕ Phone or voice
Live answers in seconds with no approve step, recording consent, no transcripts today, and no engineer capacity. Year 2, as assist first.

✕ Discounting or price matching
Prices are the same everywhere by agreement with the OTAs, and the PMS cannot discount. Nothing to negotiate.

✕ Group pricing
The groups specialists own it. The AI agent only passes groups on with the details.

✕ A website chatbot
A new channel. Not where the problem is. Year 2 once the AI agent is trusted.

6 Where AI is the wrong answer

PROBLEM	WHY NOT AI	WHAT FIXES IT
Groups: 16% of the work, 3% of contacts 45 min each, pricing and contracting	Pricing a group is a judgement call	Straight to the groups specialists with the details. The AI agent only routes; no time saving claimed.
Email stuck behind the phone phones ring, emails lose	It is a roster problem	Split phone and email shifts by hour. Answer room enquiries first.
23% of promises broken notes box read on arrival day	The PMS already has to-dos with owners and dates (traces). Hotels don't use them.	Log requests only as traces. Daily list per department. Weekly "promises kept" % per hotel. AI agent creates the trace.
A refund because a parent is in hospital non-refundable booking, compassionate case	A person with authority should decide, and be seen to.	Manager queue, decided the same day. The AI agent drafts only the kind holding reply.
Headcount as the goal team reads it as "AI is replacing us"	A tool built to cut the team is resisted by the team.	Target speed and kept promises. Headcount follows: no reduction planned; replacing leavers decided on measured hours.

7 Reply to the COO

An AI agent taking bookings on every channel in 3 months	**Yes to the AI agent.** Email in Q1, WhatsApp by end Q1, OTA messaging in Q2, phone in year 2. Not because code is slow, but because channel access, GDPR sign-off and proof of safety take real weeks, and two engineers can only build so much. Policy questions are answered alone from the first live week, after two weeks of shadow mode. Everything else is approved by a person until the AI agent earns it. The last bot was switched off for one bad promise; this one never confirms what the hotel has not.
24/7	By end of Q1, within the hour in opening hours. By Q2, around the clock for the types that send alone. Year 2 for the rest.
Headcount down 40% by year end	**The numbers don't support it.** Thirteen people would be at least 99% busy even if the AI agent delivers everything I estimate, which is today's problem again. I am not planning a reduction. Nine people leave every year anyway; whether we replace them is decided on measured hours at the end of Q1 and again at the end of Q2, not now. Headcount is worth about EUR 0.4M a year at most (9 people × EUR 45k). The conversion gap, 34% versus 9%, is worth EUR 5M to 9M. That is the prize.
Tell me the plan	This memo, the PRD with the AI agent's behaviour spec and metrics, and a working prototype. **From you:** the three work changes in section 4; a named sponsor at each hotel for traces, with the "promises kept" number in your weekly review; and a message to the team in week one: the target is speed and kept promises, and nobody is being replaced by the tool they are training.

Assumptions written down. 22 people × 37.5 productive hours = 825 h a week; 2 managers, 3 groups and events specialists, 4 seniors, 13 agents; one shared queue; desk open 07:00–23:00, seven days. Average booking EUR 1,350 (three nights × EUR 450); loaded cost per agent EUR 45k. Handle-time reductions behind the impact figures are estimates to be measured in shadow mode. Email and WhatsApp APIs available; OTA partner APIs need approval. PMS traces accept a department, due date and restricted flag; if not, sensitive detail stays in our system with a pointer. Two engineers for two quarters (~52 engineer-weeks) cover PMS integration and traces, email, WhatsApp, the AI agent, the desk, guardrails and a pilot, with a five-week buffer.